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SURVEY OF HEALTH, AGEING AND RETIREMENT IN EUROPE

The Qualitative Pretest Interview

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NIH National Institute on Aging

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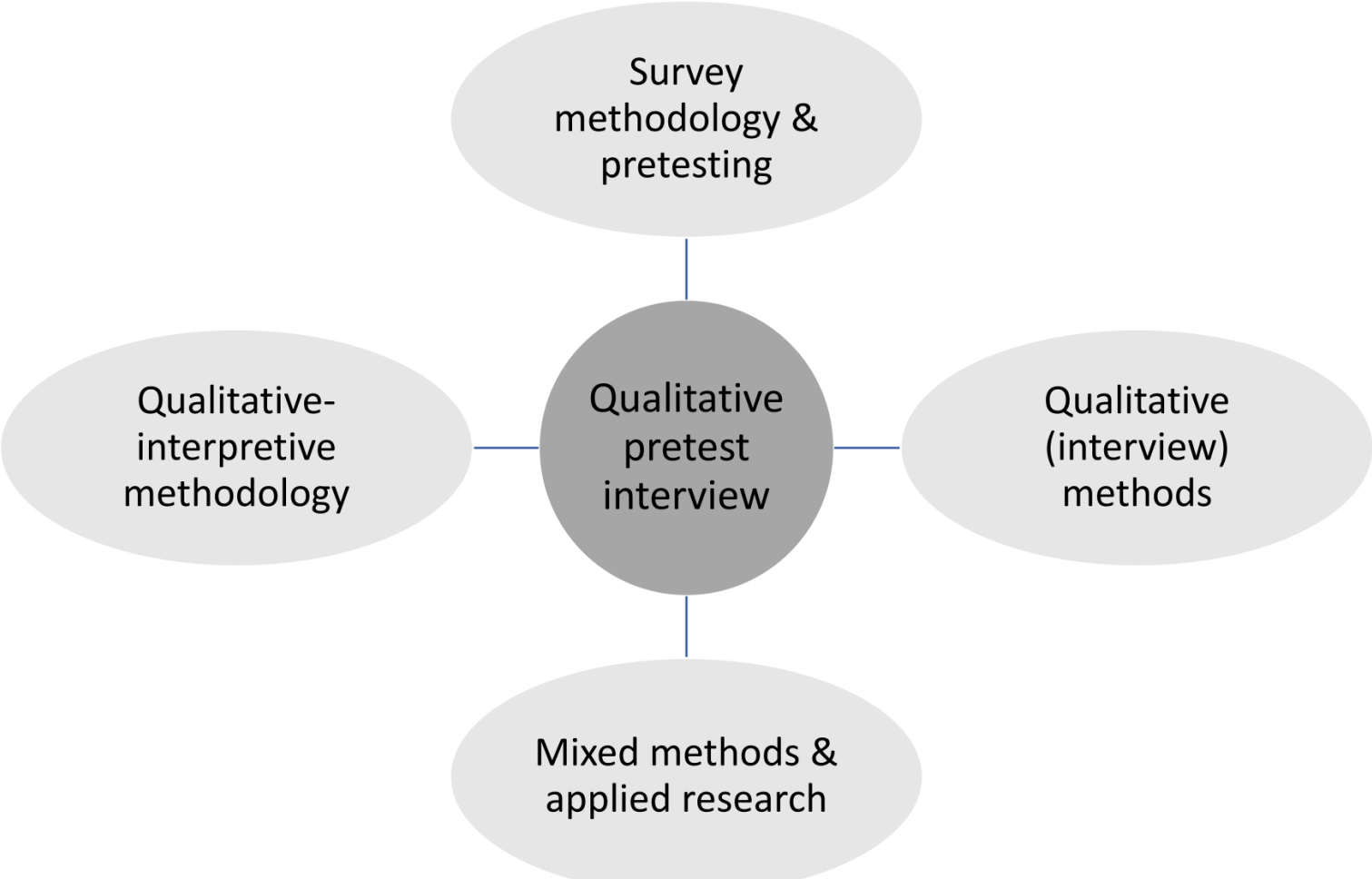
Background

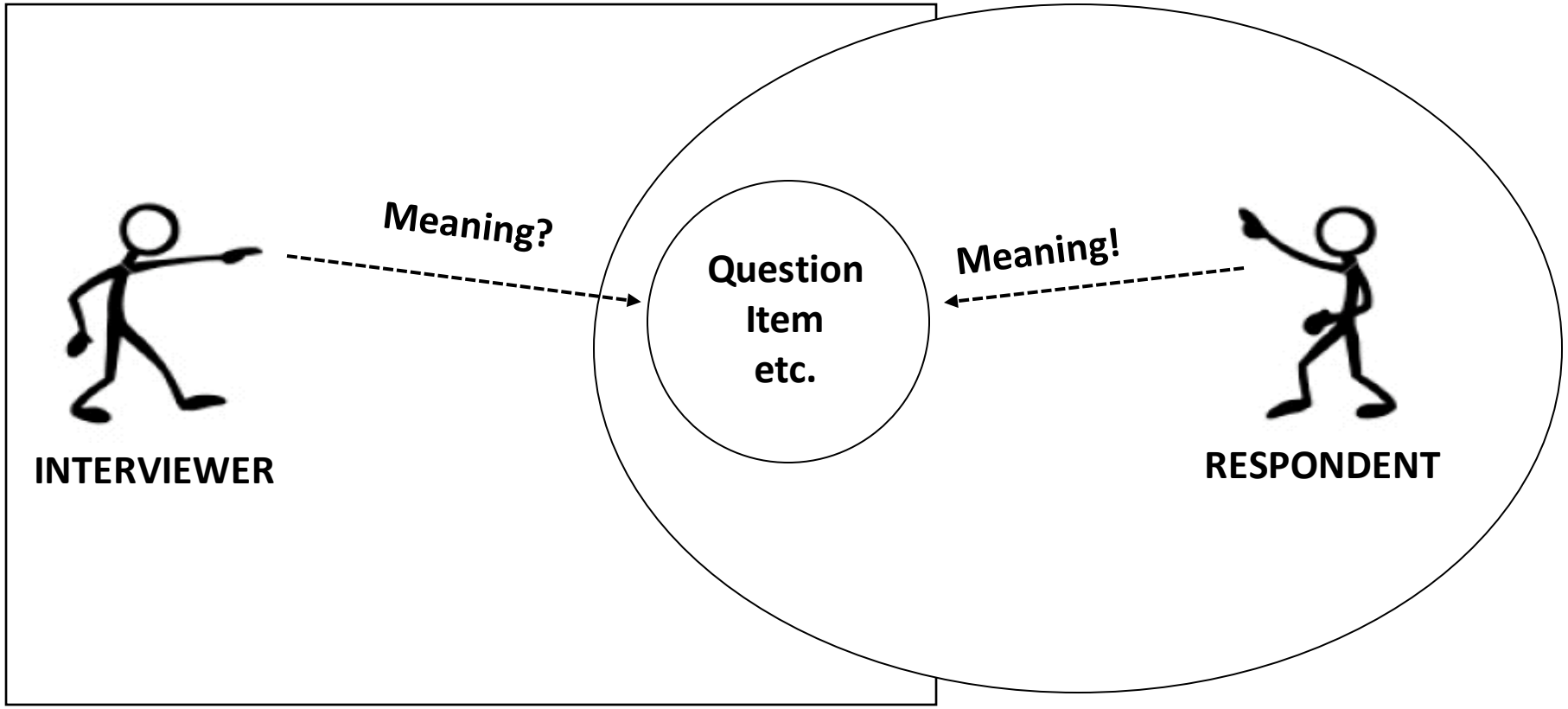

Survey methodology & pretesting
Qualitative-interpretive methodology
Qualitative pretest interview
Qualitative (interview) methods
Mixed methods & applied research

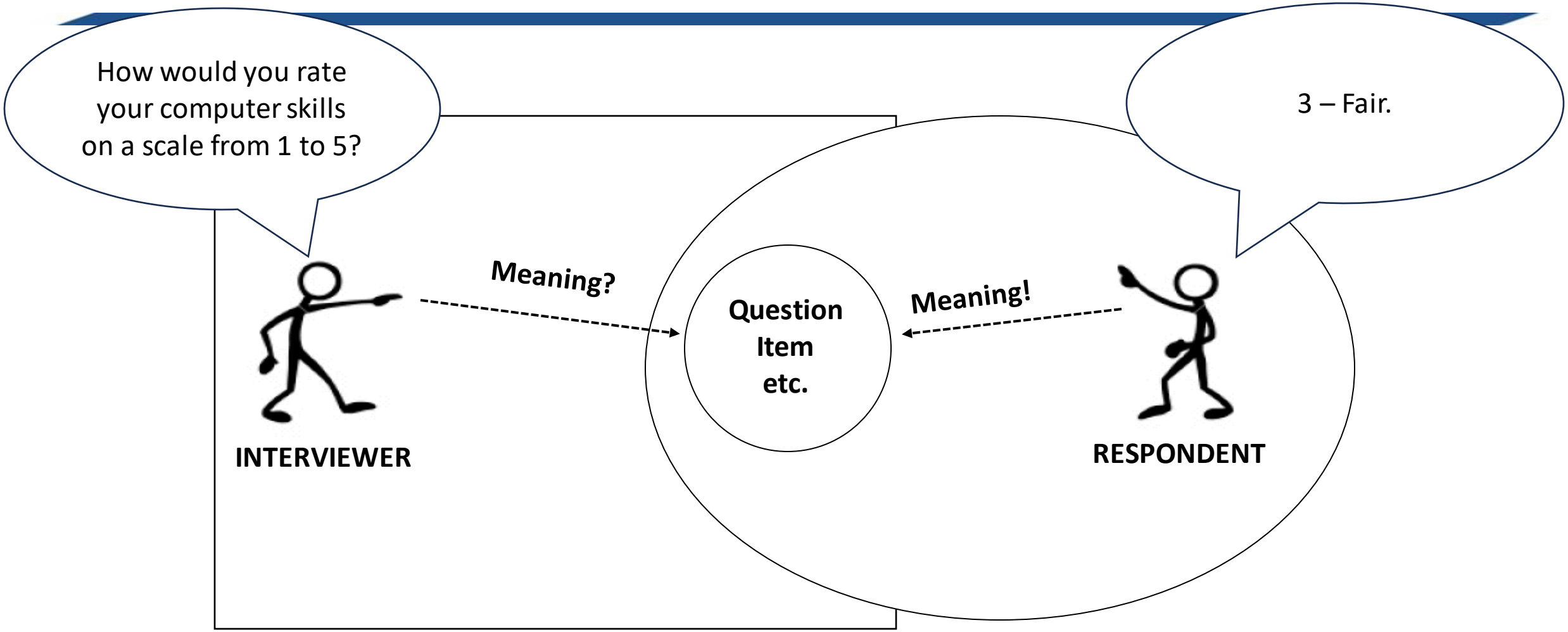
Principles

"How can we formulate questions (and other standardised stimuli) in such a way that they are understood adequately and produce answers that we can consider valid?"

1. Clarification of comprehension as a social process of negotiating meaning through intersubjective understanding
2. Involve interview partners as co-experts for this process in a dialogic clarification, in everyday language, of manifest and implied meanings and understanding

Intersubjective understanding




How would you rate your computer skills on a scale from 1 to 5?
3 – Fair.
Meaning?
Meaning!
Question Item etc.
INTERVIEWER
RESPONDENT

IP: “How would you rate your computer skills? Would you say they are excellent, very good, good, average, poor, I have never used a computer”. Well, I would say good to fair.

I: Mhm (affirmative) and if you […] are only allowed to tick one, could you assign yourself?

IP: “Fair”. Because I think there is no one who knows computers WELL. […] [I]t's such a complex subject now that probably 95 percent of the people who work with computers have only a mediocre knowledge of what they're doing.

I: So that means you would set your frame of reference very high, because, as you said, you have worked professionally with software […]?

IP: Yes.

Communication strategies

- Dialogic clarification through active listening and active understanding of the interviewer
- Adopted from the Problem-centred Interview (Witzel/Reiter 2012) for the purpose of the QPI
- Direct negotiation of implied meaning
- Combining communication strategies of general and specific exploration

Briefing

- Goal of the QPI – interest in if/how of understanding & why of answering
- Establishing the interview partner as co-expert – critical reviewer of questionnaire
- General exploration and thinking aloud – flow of thoughts
- Anticipating unusual interventions – spontaneous interruptions, struggle

General exploration

- Collection of contextualised expressions
- Applied to each survey question, item etc.
- Dynamics – mostly monologic

Strategy:

- Respondent is invited to read out the item/question
- Respondent is invited to express thoughts regarding the item by thinking aloud
- Active listening – interviewer follows the account, takes notes, prepares follow-up

Specific exploration

- Development of first interpretations
- Clarification of possible misunderstandings
- Dynamics – mostly dialogic
- Active understanding – interviewer is engaged in the clarification of meaning

Strategies:

  - Comprehension questions: interviewer clarifies evasive, incomplete answers
  - Mirroring: interviewer summarises and rephrases expressions
  - Confrontations: interviewer explores contradictions
- Back and forth between reference systems of interviewer resp. Respondent
- Dialogue and active negotiation encourages involvement

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Key Points of the QPI

- Method of pretest interviewing
- Involvement of interview partners as *co-experts*
- Underlying concept: clarification of comprehension as a social process of *negotiating meaning through intersubjective understanding*
- *Direct negotiation* of manifest and implied meanings and understandings of formulations and expressions
- Communication strategies (*active listening* & *active understanding*)

Thank you for your attention!

Questions?

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